



BE READY.

Pre-season

Your sessions

Explosiveness + Fitness

Program

Pre-season

Duration

8 weeks

Session

45 to 60 min

Place

Home

For personal use only, do not share. This program is for people in good health: if you feel pain, have an injury or are in doubt, stop and ask a health professional for advice.

Your goals

Explosiveness

In handball, the decisive actions last less than 3 seconds: a first step to break into a gap, a change of direction to beat your opponent, a sprint back on defence.

- **Speed:** moving fast over a few metres.
- **Acceleration:** reaching your top speed as early as possible.
- **Changes of direction and agility:** braking, reorienting and setting off again without losing time.

The golden rules

- **Every rep flat out**, or nearly: quality matters more than quantity.
- **Recover fully** between reps: it is normal to wait.
- **Stop the set** if you slow down or your landings get heavy.
- Non-slip floor and shoes that hold your feet well.

Level 1: no more than **60 jumps** per session. Level 2: 80. Level 3: 100. Every landing counts as a jump.

Fitness

During a match, players cover about 4 km on average, alternating walking, running, sprints and contacts (Wagner et al., 2014). What makes the difference at the end of a game is the ability to repeat intense efforts and recover quickly between them.

- **Endurance:** the base that lets you recover between actions.
- **Repeated effort capacity:** stringing sprints together without losing speed.
- **Fat loss:** increasing energy expenditure while keeping your performance.
- **General fitness:** lasting a whole match and a whole season.

The golden rules

- **Progressive:** the volume goes up week after week, never all at once.
- **Stick to the paces:** easy = you can talk; steady = a few words; hard = impossible to talk.
- On repeated sprints, stop the set if your speed drops clearly.

Fat loss: training increases energy expenditure, but the result depends mostly on food and sleep. Avoid restrictive diets, which lower performance. For support, see a registered dietitian.

When three durations are given ("12-15-18 min"), they are for levels 1, 2 and 3.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

How to read your sessions

- Every session is written out in full, in order: do the steps from top to bottom.
- "2-4 × 8": 2 sets at level 1, 3 at level 2, 4 at level 3, of 8 reps. "2-3 × 8": 2 sets at levels 1 and 2, 3 at level 3.
- The number in front of each exercise refers to its illustrated sheet, at the end of this document.
- If you do not know your level, read the guide again, page "Choosing your level".

Weeks 1-2 · Getting started

Get your body used to effort again and learn the movements. Effort 5-6 out of 10.

Fitness: build your endurance base, gently.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 EXPLOSIVENESS

15-20 min

9	 Stable landing (snap-down)	2-4 × 5	45 s
10	 Pogos	2-3 × 10	45 s
8	Progressive accelerations (15 m at 80 %)	4 runs	walk back

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

11	Easy run	12-15-18 min	
12	 High knees	4 × 15 m	walk back

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 EXPLOSIVENESS

15-20 min

15	 Lateral bound with stable landing	2-3 × 4 per leg	45 s
16	 Braking	3-5 runs	60 s
10	 Pogos	2 × 10	45 s

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

17	 Circuit training	2-3 rounds	90 s between rounds
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4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

18	 Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
19	 Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
20	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 EXPLOSIVENESS

15-20 min

21	 Squat jump	2-3 × 5	60 s
22	 10 m starts (at 90 %)	4-6 runs	60 s
9	 Stable landing (snap-down)	2 × 5	45 s

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

11	Easy run	10-12-15 min	
23	15-15 intervals (introduction)	4-5-6 min	

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

24	 Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
25	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
26	 Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Week after week, you can add the optional bonus session:

Session D (bonus, optional) - 20 min

1 WARM-UP

10 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 PREVENTION AND MOBILITY

10 min

5	 Plank	2 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 3	60 s
27	 90/90 hip mobility	1 × 8 per side	
28	 Ankle mobility at the wall	1 × 10 per side	
29	 Upper back rotation	1 × 8 per side	

Weeks 3-5 - Building up

Increase the loads gradually. Week 5 is the heaviest. Effort 7-8 out of 10.

Explosiveness: you maintain your speed and refine your technique while the loads go up elsewhere.

Fitness: intervals come in.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 EXPLOSIVENESS

15-20 min

21	 Squat jump	3-4 × 5	60 s
22	 10 m starts	5-6 runs	75 s
30	 5-10-5 shuttle	2-4 runs	90 s

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

23	15-15 intervals	2 × 6-7-8 min	3 min between blocks
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4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 EXPLOSIVENESS

15-20 min

31	 Broad jumps and triple jump (broad jumps)	3-4 × 3	75 s
15	 Lateral bound with stable landing	3 × 5 per leg	45 s
16	 Braking	4-6 runs	60 s

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

17	 Circuit training	3-4 rounds	90 s between rounds
32	Handball shuttles	4 × 30 s	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

18	 Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
19	 Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
20	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 EXPLOSIVENESS

15-20 min

10	 Pogos	3 × 15	45 s
33	 Reactive starts	6-8 runs	60 s
34	20 m sprint	3-4 runs	2 min

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

11	Easy run	15-18-20 min	
35	30-30 intervals	6-8-10 reps	

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

24	 Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
25	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
26	 Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Weeks 6-7 · Intensity

Less volume, more speed: every rep at maximum quality. Effort 7-8 out of 10.

Explosiveness: this is the key phase, every rep at maximum intensity.

Fitness: short, repeated efforts, like in a match.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 EXPLOSIVENESS

15-20 min

21	 Squat jump (maximum height)	3-4 × 4	90 s
36	 Drop jump (level 3) (levels 1 and 2: squat jump)	3 × 4	90 s
34	20 m sprint	4-5 runs	2 min

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

37	Repeated sprints	2-3 sets	3 min
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4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 EXPLOSIVENESS

15-20 min

31	 Broad jumps and triple jump (triple jump)	3-4 × 3	90 s
15	 Lateral bound with stable landing (back to back, no pause)	3 × 6 per leg	60 s
30	 5-10-5 shuttle	3-5 runs	90 s

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

23	15-15 intervals	2 × 8 min	3 min
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4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

18	 Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
19	 Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
20	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP		10-12 min	
1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back
2 EXPLOSIVENESS		15-20 min	
33	 Reactive starts	6-10 runs	60 s
16	 Braking (then re-accelerate over 5 m)	4-6 runs	75 s
10	 Pogos	3 × 15	45 s
3 FITNESS		15-20 min	
32	Handball shuttles	6 × 30 s	30 s
11	Easy run (recovery)	10 min	
4 CORE AND PREVENTION		5-8 min	
24	 Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
25	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
26	 Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s
5 COOL-DOWN		5 min	
2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.			

Week 8 - Taper

Repeat sessions A, B and C from weeks 6-7 doing **half the sets**, at the same intensity. You will start the season with your club in top shape.

- **Explosiveness:** No drop jumps this week.
- **Fitness:** Halve the duration or the number of sets, keep the intensity.

The exercises

In the order of the numbers used in your sessions.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

1 Light jog and running drills

Light jog, alternating side shuffles, high knees and butt kicks.

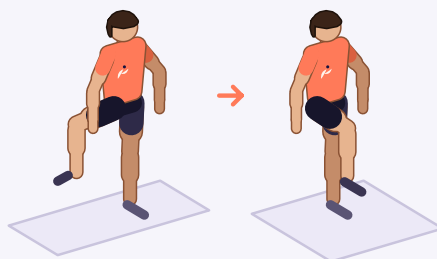
Key points: Start slowly, then gradually pick up the pace.



2 Forward lunge with trunk rotation

Arms straight out in front of you, take a big step forward and lower into a lunge, then turn your trunk and arms towards the front leg. Come back and switch legs.

Key points: Front knee above the ankle, slow rotation.



3 Walking hip opener

On the spot or walking: lift your knee out to the side as if stepping over a fence, bring it round in front of you at the same height, then put your foot down. Switch legs.

Key points: Upright trunk, big circle with the knee.



4



Glute bridge

On your back, knees bent, feet on the floor, lift your hips until shoulders, hips and knees are in line, then lower.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes at the top, do not arch your lower back. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.



5



Plank

On your forearms and toes, body in a straight line from head to heels.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes and abs, breathe normally.

Easier: Knees on the floor.



6



Single-leg balance

On one foot, knee slightly bent, the other foot off the floor behind you, arms relaxed: hold the position without moving. To progress: close your eyes, then stand on a cushion.

Key points: The knee stays over the foot, the pelvis level.



7



Small jump, stable landing

Small jump on the spot, land softly on both feet and hold the position for 2 seconds.

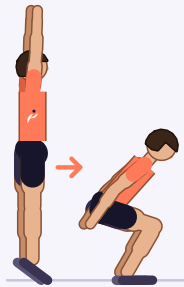
Key points: Land on the balls of your feet, knees bent and in line with your toes: they never cave inwards. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

8

Progressive accelerations

Run 15 m, building up speed: 60 %, then 80 %, then 90 % of your top speed. Walk back.

Key points: Relaxed, shoulders loose.



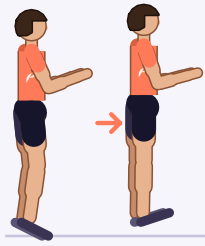
9



Stable landing (snap-down)

Standing, arms up, drive yourself down by pulling your arms back and land in a half squat on both feet. Hold for 2 seconds.

Key points: Knees in line with your toes, chest over your knees, silent landing.



10 Pogos

Small quick jumps on the spot, legs almost straight: your ankles do the bouncing.

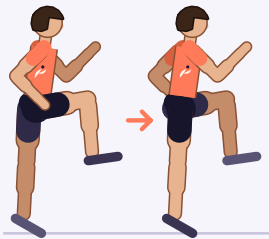
Key points: Shortest possible ground contact. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

Easier: Lower jumps, slower rhythm.

11 **Easy run**

Continuous running at a pace where you can hold a conversation.

Key points: If you cannot talk, slow down or alternate running and walking.



12 High knees

Over 15 m moving forward (or on the spot), drive your knees up quickly.

Key points: On the balls of your feet, active arms.



13 Side plank

On your side, on your forearm (elbow under the shoulder) and the edge of your foot, body in line, hips high, top arm reaching up to the ceiling.

Key points: The hips do not drop.

Easier: Knees on the floor.

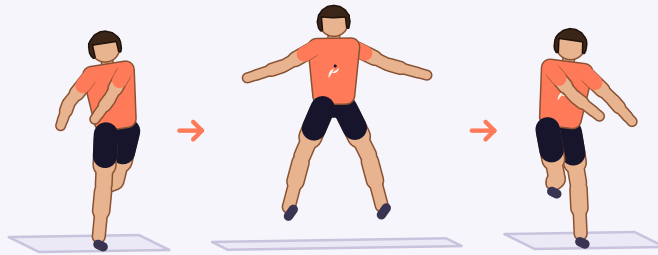


14 Nordic hamstring curl

Kneeling on a cushion, feet anchored under the sofa or held by another person, lean forward as slowly as possible, body straight. Catch yourself with your hands, then push back up with your hands.

Key points: Hips extended: the body stays straight from the knees to the head.

Easier: Shorter descent.

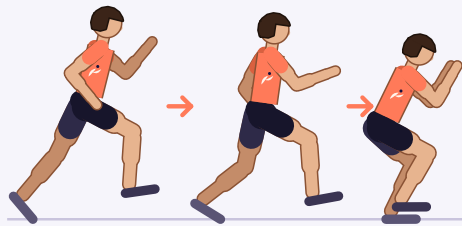


15 Lateral bound with stable landing

On one leg, jump sideways onto the other leg and hold for 2 seconds, like a skater.

Key points: The standing knee stays in line on landing. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

Easier: Shorter jump, the free foot touches the floor to help.

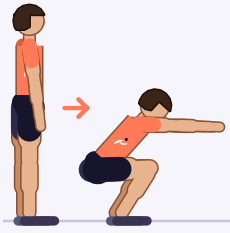


16 Braking

Sprint 10 m, then come to a complete stop in 3 steps, in a low defensive stance.

Key points: Low centre of gravity, wide base, knees in line. Never brake with straight legs: bend your knees to absorb, otherwise the impact goes into your joints.

Squats



Push-ups



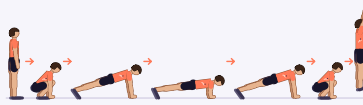
Alternating lunges



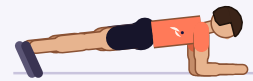
Mountain climbers



Burpees



Plank



17

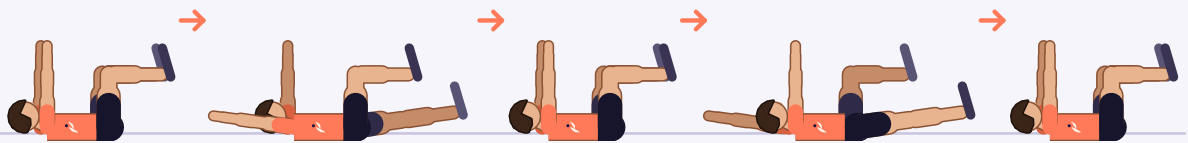


Circuit training

30 seconds of each exercise in a row: squats, push-ups, alternating lunges, mountain climbers, burpees, plank.

Key points: Quality of movement before speed.

Easier: 20 seconds of work, 10 seconds of rest.



18



Dead bug

On your back, arms straight up towards the ceiling, knees bent at 90°. Extend one arm and the opposite leg without touching the floor, then switch sides.

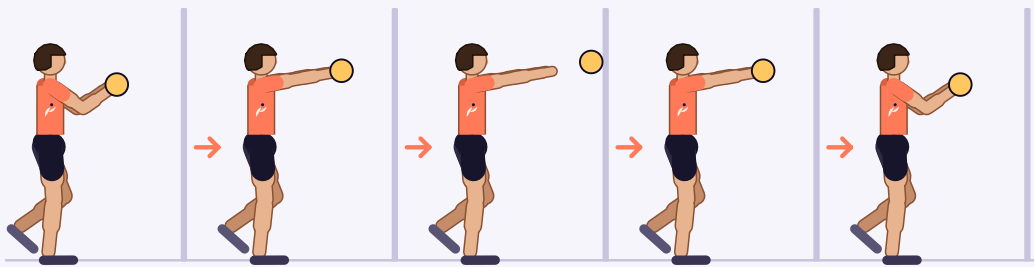
Key points: Your lower back stays pressed to the floor.



19 Y-T-W

Lying face down, forehead on a towel. Lift your arms off the floor to draw three letters with your body: Y (arms straight, diagonally above your head), T (arms out to the sides), then W (elbows bent, pulled in close to your ribs). Hold each letter for 2 seconds, squeezing your shoulder blades.

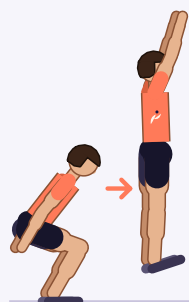
Key points: Thumbs towards the ceiling, no arching.



20 Balance with a ball

On one leg, throw a ball against a wall and catch it. Harder: standing on a folded cushion.

Key points: The standing knee stays in line.

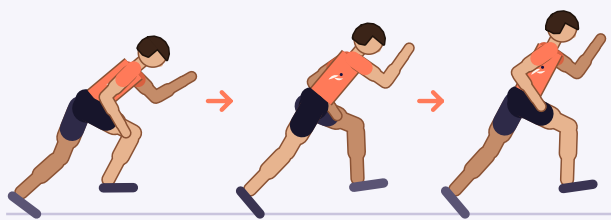


21 Squat jump

Lower into a half squat, pause for one second, then jump as high as you can. Stable landing.

Key points: Push hard into the floor, arms helping. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

Easier: Without the pause.



22 10 m starts

Split-stance start, trunk leaning forward. Sprint flat out for 10 m.

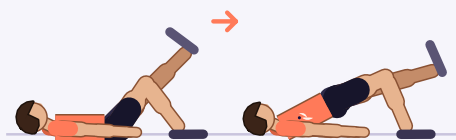
Key points: Short, powerful first steps, arms driving back.

23 15-15 intervals

15 seconds of fast running, 15 seconds of walking or very slow jogging, continuously.

Key points: Same distance on every rep: pick a finish point.

Easier: 15 seconds fast, 30 seconds of recovery.



24 Single-leg glute bridge

Like the glute bridge, with one leg straight in the air.

Key points: The pelvis stays level. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.



25 Copenhagen plank

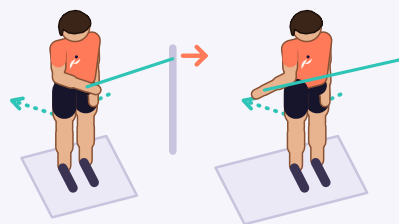
On your side, on your forearm (elbow under the shoulder), top leg resting on the sofa or a chair (at the knee, or at the foot to make it harder). Lift your hips, reach your top arm up to the ceiling and hold the position.

Key points: Body in line: the inside of the top thigh does the work.

At home



With a band



26 Shoulder external rotation

Lying on your side, top elbow tucked against your waist and bent at 90°, a water bottle in your hand, forearm resting in front of your belly: lift your forearm towards the ceiling by pivoting around the elbow (the hand moves away from your belly), then lower slowly.

With a band: Standing, band anchored to the side: elbow tucked in, move your forearm outwards.

Key points: The elbow does not move, 2 seconds on the way back.

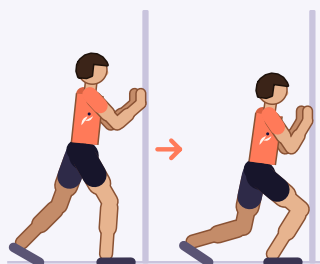
Easier: Without a band.



27 90/90 hip mobility

Seated on the floor, hands on the floor behind you, feet flat and wider than your hips, knees up. Let both knees drop to the same side into the 90/90 position: front leg bent at 90° in front of you, back leg bent at 90° out to the side. Bring the knees back up through the middle and over to the other side, like windscreen wipers.

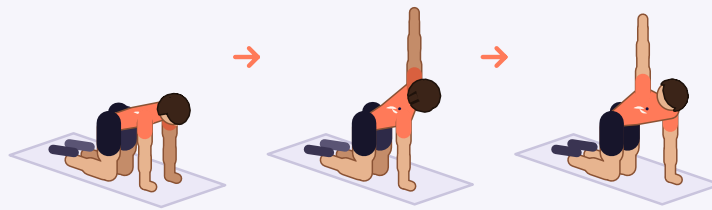
Key points: Upright trunk, slow movement. Only go as far as your hips allow, pain-free.



28 Ankle mobility at the wall

Facing a wall, hands on it, front foot 10 cm from the wall and the other foot behind: drive your front knee forward to touch the wall without lifting your heel.

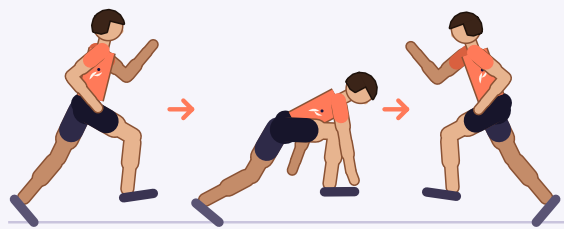
Key points: Heel glued to the floor. Move your foot back if it is easy.



29 Upper back rotation

On all fours, hands under your shoulders. Rotate your upper back as you reach one arm towards the ceiling, following your hand with your eyes, then bring it back down and do the same with the other arm.

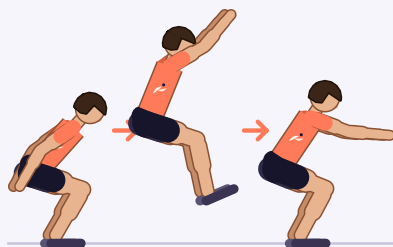
Key points: The pelvis does not move.



30 5-10-5 shuttle

Start in the middle: 5 m to the right (touch the line), 10 m to the left (touch), back to the middle.

Key points: Get low before each change of direction, push off with the outside leg.



31 Broad jumps and triple jump

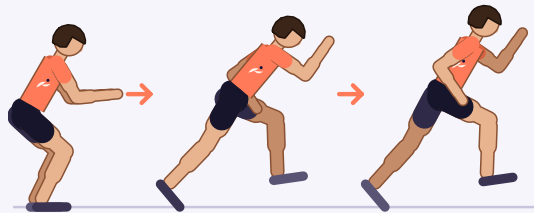
Standing long jump from both feet, stable landing: this is what the animation shows. Triple jump: three jumps in a row, right foot, left foot, then land on both feet.

Key points: Arms swinging forward, controlled landing. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

32 Handball shuttles

Back and forth between two lines 10 m apart: forwards, side shuffling and backwards.

Key points: Stay low in the changes of direction.



33 Reactive starts

Start on a partner's signal (clap, voice) or react to a dropped ball. Vary the starting position: facing forward (as in the animation), facing backward, side shuffling.

Key points: React, don't guess.

34 20 m sprint

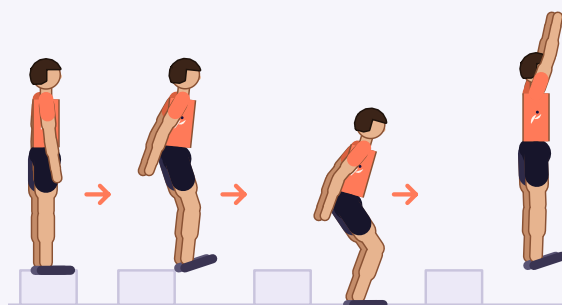
Sprint at top speed over 20 m.

Key points: Relaxed, shoulders loose.

35 30-30 intervals

30 seconds fast (you can only say a few words), 30 seconds of jogging.

Key points: Steady pace from one rep to the next.



36 Drop jump (level 3)

Step off a stair step (20-30 cm) and, as soon as your feet touch the floor, bounce up as high as you can.

Key points: Very short contact. Only if your landings are perfect. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

37 Repeated sprints

6 sprints of 20 m. You go again every 20 seconds: the time left is for walking back.

Key points: Every sprint flat out.